Given the discovery of the SAMs, time was of the essence, and the fastest way to deliver the nuclear weapons would be by air, but Malinovsky reported to Khrushchev that while Soviet planes could deliver the missiles and nuclear warheads to Cuba, they could not deliver the much larger launching pads. Without them, the missiles and warheads would be useless. Malinovsky proposed to send the bombers, rockets, nuclear charges, and bombs for them by sea: the nuclear warheads and bombs would travel together with the nuclear warheads for medium- and intermediate-range missiles on the dry cargo ship *Indigirka*, scheduled to depart on September 15, with the tactical missiles to follow in early October. On September 7 Khrushchev approved the dispatch to Cuba by sea of six IL-26 bombers with atomic bombs and three divisions of Luna tactical missiles with nuclear charges for them.[10]

Khrushchev's decision to dispatch tactical nuclear weapons to Cuba reflected his state of urgency, if not panic, after the release of Kennedy's statement. It marked a dramatic shift in his thinking about the Cuban situation from a desire to use nuclear weapons as a deterrent against an American invasion of Cuba and as a way of redressing the balance of nuclear forces worldwide to readiness to use them in an actual conflict with the United States. There is nothing in Khrushchev's documents, pronouncements, or comments suggesting that he was trying to unleash a nuclear war with the United States on either a local or a global scale, that he preferred the former to the latter, or believed that it was possible to have the one without the other. But his decision to send tactical nuclear weapons to Cuba made all those scenarios not just theoretically but practically possible.[11]

On September 8, the day after Khrushchev approved the transfer of tactical nuclear weapons to Cuba, Malinovsky and Marshal Matvei Zakharov, the chief of staff of the Soviet armed forces, ordered the shipment to Cuba of six nuclear bombs for IL-28 bombers and twelve nuclear warheads for the Luna missiles. Malinovsky and Zakharov also signed a new instruction to the commander of the Cuban Task Force, General Issa Pliev, which postulated the use of nuclear weapons to counter an invasion of Cuba. "The task of the Soviet armed forces group on the island of Cuba is not to allow an enemy landing on Cuban territory," read